



TBILISI GEORGIA

Satsivi in Medieval Tbilisi

Perched on the slopes above the Kura River, and sprinkled with medieval churches and old wooden houses, the capital of Georgia is one of the most atmospheric cities you could hope to visit. It is also one of the few places in Georgia where you are likely to find *satsivi*, one of the most famous and memorable dishes in a country renowned for its cuisine.



The Georgian capital, Tbilisi, has an almost kaleidoscopic range of architecture, from ancient stone churches to grand

Soviet constructions, and traditional wooden houses to modern high-rise buildings. The city is around ten times the size of any other city in Georgia, yet it is small enough to get around the main sites on foot. It was founded in the 5th century by the Georgian king Vakhtang Gorgasali, whose fortress stood on the site of the present Metekhi church above the Kura River; there is a statue of the ruler next to the church.

Among the city's narrow lanes and along its broad avenues you'll stumble upon everything from cafés to carpet shops and thermal baths, and some first-rate theaters and museums, together with a wider choice of restaurants than anywhere else in the country. *Satsivi* is one of Georgia's most luxurious dishes, and this classic concoction is often served on festive occasions. Appearing deceptively simple, *satsivi* is essentially a whole portioned turkey, or sometimes chicken, bathed in a thick walnut sauce – and therein lies the secret. The sauce is a mix of ground walnuts and a distinctive blend of spices that incorporates coriander, cinnamon, cloves, paprika, a sprinkling of chili pepper flakes,

and a touch of saffron or ground marigold petals. A similar, ready-made spice mix called *khmeli-suneli* is sometimes used. The turkey (or chicken) is poached, then roasted, and finally combined with a sauce made from the poaching liquid and the ground walnuts, onions, garlic, and spices. The *satsivi* is not served piping hot – the dish is allowed to stand for a period before serving, its sauce thickening as it cools to room temperature. Any extra sauce is eagerly scooped up with bread or *gomi* (polenta-like cornmeal porridge). The Georgians even have a summer version of *satsivi* called *bazhe*, another nut-based sauce dish that uses chicken or turkey, but fewer spices.

Georgian feasts are legendary, and eating out in Georgia is a genuinely memorable experience. As well as dishes such as *satsivi* and *chakapuli* (lamb with fresh tarragon and other herbs), there is a wide range of delicious appetizers, including more unusual ones such as *khachapuri*, a delicious cheese-filled bread. No self-respecting Georgian table would be complete without a plate of *khinkali* – fig-shaped, meat-filled dumplings eaten with plenty of freshly ground black pepper. The challenge lies in holding these by the “stem” and catching the flood of juice that runs out with the first bite.

A Day in Tbilisi

A walking tour of Tbilisi is the best way to see its historic churches and explore the warren of streets that run through the old town and up to the hilltop fort.

MORNING Start at **Rustaveli Avenue**, then head downhill past the State and Rustaveli theaters and the **Kashveti church**, to **Freedom Square** and the historic **Sioni Cathedral**. Continue to the Kura River, crossing the Metekhi bridge to the **Metekhi church** and the statue of the founder of Tbilisi, Vakhtang Gorgasali.

AFTERNOON Return to the southern side of the river and head up through the warren of old streets of the old town (with their bathhouses) to the **Narikala fortress** and the **botanical gardens**. From here walk west to the huge statue of **Kartlis Deda**, Mother of Kartli (the central region of Georgia), who – in true Georgian fashion – wields an enormous sword in one hand while the other holds a bowl of wine.

EVENING Wander back down through the old town for dinner – and wine – on the terrace at Hotel Kopala.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Tbilisi's **international airport**, around 9 miles (15 km) outside town, is connected to the city by **bus, train, and taxi**.

WHERE TO STAY

Irine's Place (inexpensive) is a hugely popular guesthouse. www.irinesplace.com

Hotel Villa Mtiebi (moderate) has stylish, Art Nouveau-decorated rooms, set around a plant-filled atrium. www.hotelmtebi.ge

The British House (moderate) has sumptuous old-style rooms. www.british-house.ge

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.info-tbilisi.com

